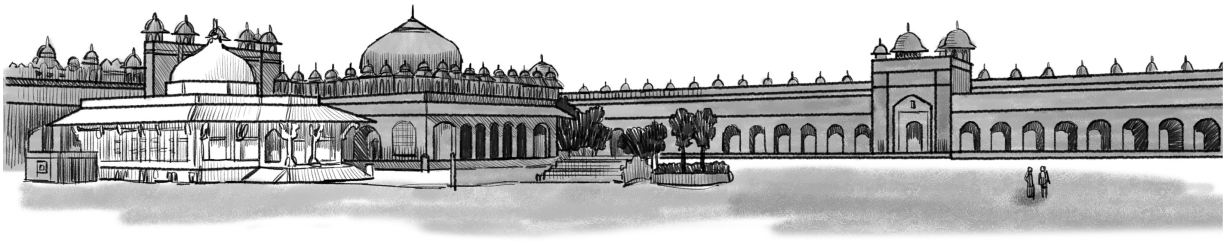
CHAPTER 9
Imprisoned

Perhaps the memories of Mumtaz became too painful for Shah Jahan to remain at the building site. Although the Taj Mahal was not finished, in 1639, he began work on a city named after him: Shahjahanabad. It was located about forty miles from Agra, on the west bank of the Yamuna River. A town named Delhi had already existed there.

The primary building in the new city was a new Red Fort. It was twice as large as the one in Agra. It was like a city in itself. Circled by a high red sandstone wall and a moat, it had twenty-seven towers and eleven great gates. Inside were grand avenues, markets, shops, courtiers' homes, government buildings, and pavilions decorated with gold and jewels. The emperor and his family lived in a private palace within the fort.

A French visitor described it: "Nearly every chamber has its reservoir of running water at the door; on every side are gardens, delightful alleys, shady retreats, streams, fountains, grottoes, deep excavations that afford shelter from the sun by day . . . [and] terraces on which to sleep coolly at night. Within the walls of this enchanting place, no oppressive or inconvenient heat is felt."



The new Red Fort

In 1648, to the beating of kettledrums, Shah Jahan arrived at the fort by boat and mounted his Peacock Throne. He was at the height of his power.